observation for two days. Fortunately, there was no ‘brain damage’, or so I assume, but I had to go around with a black eye for many days. My company commander happened to watch this fight. I suppose he must have raised my ranking in the order of merit a couple of notches higher, for displaying grit and determination and taking the bashing in a manly way. That was the last time that I boxed.

My father came to attend my passing-out parade and the pipping ceremony on 2 August 1964. He put on a single star on each of my shoulders and embraced me. He had tears in his eyes as he recalled his own commissioning at this very same IMA parade ground in 1943. This was the dawn of a third-generation soldier of the Indian Army. To celebrate, my father offered me my first glass of beer, and we clinked our glasses as we said cheers. Then my father said that henceforth, we shall be ‘brother officers’ first, and father and son later. It was one of the happiest days of my life. How I wished that my mother was also there to bless me and share this moment of joy. But she couldn’t come as she was supervising the construction of our house in Defence Colony in Delhi.